
Paper 3, Option 32:

The Golden Age of Spain, 1474–1598

Overview

This option comprises two parts: the *Aspects in breadth* focus on long-term changes and contextualise the *Aspects in depth*, which focus in detail on key episodes.

Together, the breadth and depth topics explore key events and developments in Spanish history at a time when Spain exercised a major influence on Europe as a whole and became what can possibly be described as the first truly world power. Within the primarily political focus on events within Spain and Spanish influence abroad, this option also gives students the opportunity to explore social and economic dimensions and the part they played in generating pressure for change.

Aspects in breadth: changes in Spanish influence and power, 1474–1598	
Themes	Content
1 Changing geographical reach of Spanish power	• The reasons for the expansion and maintenance of Spanish power throughout Italy and the Mediterranean, 1474–1598; the struggle with France and the Turks (key developments: Ferdinand being recognised as King of Naples 1504; the Battle of Pavia and the capture of Francis I in 1525; the capture of Tunis 1535; the siege of Malta 1565). • Extending influence to the north and west, 1474–1598: building an empire in the New World, the significance of northern Europe and Portugal (key developments: Columbus's first voyage 1492, the impact of Cortés and the conquest of the Aztecs 1521, Pizarro's conquest of the Incas 1532, the marriage to Mary Tudor 1554 and her death 1558, the revolt in the Netherlands 1572, the conquest of Portugal 1580).
2 Changing military and financial power	• The growing power of the Spanish army, 1474–1598 and key figures: Gonzalo de Córdoba, the Duke of Alba and Alexander Farnese, Prince of Parma. The significance of naval power, 1474–1598 (key developments: the use of Genoa and Andrea Doria from 1528, galley building from 1560, the Battle of Lepanto 1571, the acquisition of the Portuguese fleet 1580, the defeat of the Spanish Armada 1588). • The changing nature and extent of financial resources, 1474–1598: the importance of Castile and the system of <i>juros</i>, the Netherlands as a source and later a drain of revenue, and revenue from the Americas (key development: the opening of the silver mine at Potosí 1545).

Aspects in depth: ruling Spain – newly united but still divided	
Key topics	Content
1 The Spanish Inquisition and the persecution of the Jews, 1478–92	• The position of Jews and <i>conversos</i> in fifteenth-century Spanish society. • The reasons for the foundation of the Inquisition in 1478–80; the roles of Queen Isabella and Tomás de Torquemada; the methods of the Inquisition and its impact on <i>conversos</i>. • The reasons for the expulsion of the Jews in 1492 and its social and economic impact on Spain.
2 The accession of Charles and the revolt of the Comuneros, 1516–29	• The significance of Charles von Habsburg's accession in 1516; the importance of Cardinal Jiménez de Cisneros. • The reasons for the outbreak of the revolt of the Comuneros and its significance; the reasons for the defeat of the revolt; the role of the great nobles. • The impact and significance of the revolt, including Charles's lengthy stay in Spain and developing good relations with the nobility and church; his relations with the Cortes of Castile.
3 The price revolution and its impact, c1500–c1570	• The significance of inflation in these years: extent and contemporary comment as a new and puzzling phenomenon. • Gold and silver imports and the contemporary discussions on their contribution to inflation; the significance of the writings of Martín de Azpilcueta 1556, and Tomás de Mercado 1568. • The impact on prices of population growth in towns and countryside. The social impact of the price revolution: winners and losers; changing social values.
4 The campaign for orthodoxy, 1558–70	• Reasons for the drive for orthodoxy; the role of de Valdés; Charles's letter to Juana in May 1558; the significance of the case of Archbishop Carranza and relations with the papacy; the impact of persecution on Protestantism, 1559–62: <i>autos da fé</i> and the index of prohibited books, 1558–59. • The reasons for the Great Rebellion 1568: the Morisco 'problem'; the impact of Turkish raids; the role of the Marquis de Mondéjar; the significance of the decrees reforming Morisco customs in Granada 1566–67. • The significance of the rebellion in Granada and the difficulty in securing its repression; the impact of the revolt on Spain in terms of economic damage and loss of life.
5 The crisis in Aragon, 1590–93	• The nature of the Kingdom of Aragón and royal authority: hostility to Castilians; the importance of local <i>fueros</i>; the significance of quarrels amongst the leading nobles. • The importance of the revolt in Zaragoza 1590, the role of Antonio Pérez in the revolt and his significance during the reign of Philip II; reasons why the revolt was easily crushed.